> flattened out; anyway, I didn’t feel good about myself. And yet he was never able to rebut any of the facts I presented and kept repeating things that are absolute falsehoods. But the press has been calling him the winner for two days now.

I had spent too many hours poring over briefing books and in skull sessions and mock debates preparing for the encounter, and on the night of the debate, I think I was just overtrained.

I don’t think anybody could have retained all the things pumped into my brain during the days leading up to the debate; I goofed a couple of times. Although I don’t blame them, in a way I was hurt by people trying to help me: A debate was coming up and everybody around me started saying, “You have to know this . . . you have to know that”; then they fill your head with all sorts of details, technicalities, and statistics as if you were getting ready to take an exam on those topics. Finally, when you’re in the debate, you realize you just can’t command all that information and still do a good job as a debater.

I don’t feel low very often, but I take pride in my public speaking ability—after all, I’m an old performer. The verdict that I’d lost the debate didn’t make me feel very happy. A lot of supporters tried to make me feel better afterward. But I knew I’d stumbled two or three times while millions of people were watching, and I was embarrassed.

After Louisville, I had some genuine reasons to feel nervous about the campaign. Several polls taken after the debate indicated that some of my supporters were having doubts about me, and some of the pundits in the press claimed my stumbles proved that I was too old to be president. One White House television correspondent even proclaimed that the Louisville debate had brought to the surface what he called the “senility factor.”